

The start from scratch approach

We have all gotten our beliefs about the world from a variety of sources. Some are based on serious thought and investigation. Some are based on what our parents told us. Some are based on what our friends told us. Some are probably based on nothing at all. If we want to really figure out what we should and should not believe, we need to avoid taking anything for granted. Instead, we should assume nothing, and test all of our beliefs against some standard to see which ones we should keep, and which ones we should get rid of.

The natural next question is: what is the standard by which we should decide which of our beliefs to keep, and which to discard?

Here again Descartes gives us an answer.

“Reason now leads me to believe that I should hold back my assent from opinions which are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I do from those which are patently false. So, for the purpose of rejecting my opinions, it will be enough if I find in each of them some reason for doubt.”

What would it mean for you to find in some belief a reason for doubt?

It seems that to find a reason for doubting a belief would be to be less than certain that the belief is true. But what things can we be certain of? One natural thought is that we can be certain only of those things that we can **prove**.

This suggests the following rule of belief:

Suppose we agree that No Good Argument $\rightarrow$ No Belief is false. What does this mean?

No Good Argument $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't give a good
argument for P, don't believe P.

It means that there are some beliefs which we should have, even if we have no good argument for them.

Let's all believe which we've, but don't have any argument for, basic beliefs.

Then the key question seems to be: which basic beliefs should we have?

Once we answer this question, then we'll know how to decide what to believe. We can use the basic beliefs which we have to form arguments for other beliefs — and if those arguments are valid, it looks like our positive Good Argument $\rightarrow$ Belief rule tells us that we should believe their conclusion. Similarly, we can form valid arguments against certain beliefs — and if we should believe the premises of these arguments, Good Argument Against $\rightarrow$ No Belief tells us to discard that belief.



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